in ExComm (and certainly did not have an especially warm relationship with the President), was not in the room.

According to Bundy, Dean Rusk suggested that RFK's oral message to Dobrynin was that 'while there could be no deal over the Turkish missiles, the president was determined to get them out and would do so once the crisis was resolved'.[55] This was agreed by everyone. It was also agreed that knowledge of the oral message should not be shared with anyone outside the room. The US commitment would be honoured only if Khrushchev kept his word. The suggestion that an agreement could be reached on a 'strictly secret basis with the Soviets' had been one of several options outlined in a telegram of 26 October from Raymond Hare, the US Ambassador to Turkey.[56] Hare's view was that the Turks would not agree to a withdrawal (though Don Munton suggests that Turkish attitudes had become more amenable than appeared).[57]

Drafting Kennedy's formal letter to Khrushchev was straightforward. Bundy describes the response as 'simple, stern, and quickly decided'. This accorded with the general conclusions hammered out in ExComm during the day. The President emphasised that the first thing necessary was 'for work to cease on offensive missile bases in Cuba capable of offensive use to be rendered inoperable, under effective United Nations arrangements'. He then made clear his agreement 'along the lines' in Khrushchev's letter of 26 October:

1. You would agree to remove these weapons systems from Cuba under appropriate United Nations observation and supervision; and undertake, with suitable safeguards, to halt the further introduction of such weapons systems into Cuba.
2. We, on our part, would agree – upon the establishment of adequate arrangements through the United Nations to ensure the carrying out and continuation of these commitments – (a) to remove promptly the quarantine measures now in effect and (b) to give assurances against an invasion of Cuba and I am confident that other nations of the Western Hemisphere would be prepared to do likewise.[58]